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Plural marriage among the Wolof in the Gambia

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CHAPTER II THE SELECTION OF MATES; COURTSHIP AND MARRIAGE

Like many other peoples, the Wolof have an institution-alized cross cousins relationship. It is especially marked by a joking relationship between the child of the mother's brother who is called "master" (borom) and the child of the father's sister who is called "slave" (jam). Cross cousins take liberties with each other that would not be countenance from others, such as the use of insulting nicknames for each other. They are supposed to take this chiding good naturedly and not show hostility, regardless of the anger they arouse in each other. The joking is especially broad between cross cousins of the opposite sex, who are potential mates. A youth was observed petting and speaking affectionately to a young woman, in public, who was several years his elder; he  48 laughingly called her his "girl friend" and explained that she was his father's sister's daughter. A woman who is her husband's cross cousin may take advantage of this relationship and fail to act in an obedient and respectful manner towards her spouse, as a "good" wife should. But when this occurs, it is obviously a source of friction. Marriage between surname groups having the mythical cross cousin relationship (gamo) ⁴ is considered desirable although they are less common than actual cross cousin marriages.

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⁴ See above p. 34.

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